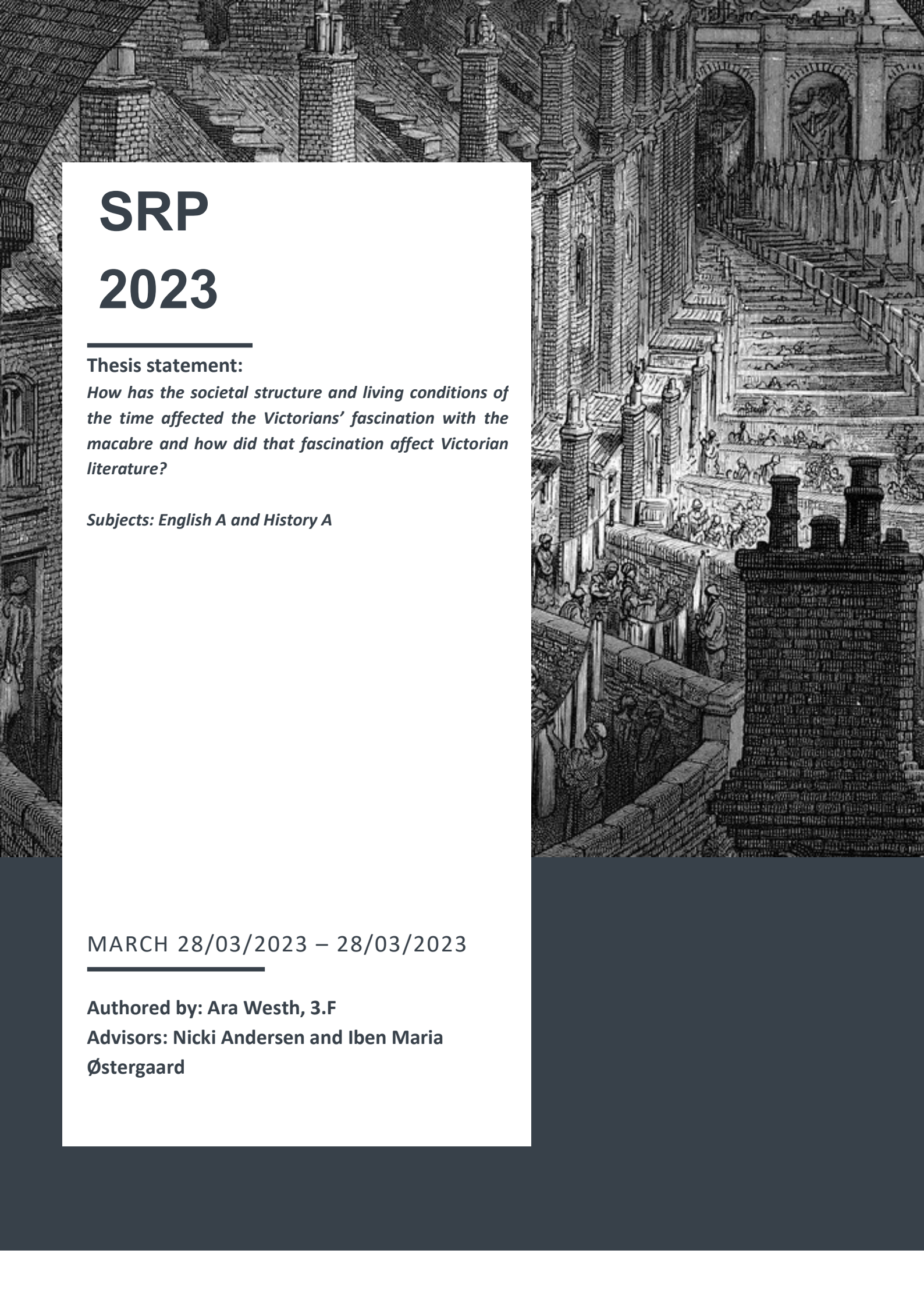




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Thesis statement:

How has the societal structure and living conditions of the time affected the Victorians' fascination with the macabre and how did that fascination affect Victorian literature?

Subjects: English A and History A

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"How has the societal structure and living conditions of the time affected the Victorians' fascination with the macabre and how did that fascination affect Victorian literature?"

Resume

In this paper the question *"How has the societal structure and living conditions of the time affected the Victorians' fascination with the macabre and how did that fascination affect Victorian literature?"* will be answered through rigorous analysis of a historical source as well as a classic literary source. The motivation behind this paper is, that many of the literary works, that we today consider classics, are from the Victorian era. The inspiration behind these works is likely found in the society and culture in which they were written. A deep dive into Victorian society, and its horrors, may reveal what parts of society and culture served as inspiration for those works. The deep dive's purpose is to figure out what effect the societal structure and living conditions of the time have had on the death culture and the literature written in the said era.

Through a source critical analysis, focusing on the useability and circumstances, in addition to the portrayal of living conditions and societal structure, of the article *"Of the Life of a Flower Girl"* by Henry Mayhew, it shall be revealed what biases there might have snuck their way into the article, as well as the picture of the lower class that the upper and middle class were given by the press, and the lower class's living conditions. An analysis conducted on Mary Shelly's *"Frankenstein"* focusing on the social setting, presentation of religion and the relationship between Victor and his Creation shall disclose how Victorian literature mirrors Victorian society.

The results of these two analyses prove that Victorian literature and Victorian society are connected. Based on the themes presented in both sources the connection seems to be related to the living conditions and societal structure and their consequences.

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Introduction

The Victorian era is one steeped in peculiar customs and inspiration. In many ways, it is one of the most formative periods for the modern world society we see today.

It Victorian era is one marked by scientific breakthroughs, industrialisation, and classic works of literature. On the less pleasant side of history, is an era marked by great social inequality, deaths, and mummy unwrapping parties. The Victorian Era stretched from 1837 to 1901, although culturally the Victorian era had already started in 1820 and lasted until the start of world war 2. It was during this time that so many of the literary works that are today considered classics originate. There is a high likelihood that without the Victorian era, we would never have seen the works of "Dracula" or "The Picture of Dorian Gray".

But what caused the inspiration for these classics? Why was the death rate so high? And what is a mummy unwrapping party? These are the questions that will be answered throughout this paper. Through an account of the living conditions and religion, An analysis of an article about a flower girl written by journalist Henry Mayhew, a man who was well known for his articles covering the lower class living conditions, a classic work of literature all about the dangers of playing god and a discussion about how living conditions effect society and literature and why "Frankenstein" is still relevant, those questions will be answered, and even more importantly the answer to the question of how societal structures and living conditions can affect literature and culture will be found.

Living Conditions and Religion

Living Conditions in the Victorian Era

Victorian society is highly categorised by one, the difference between social classes and by two, a high population density, both of which affect the overall living conditions of the time. At the turn of the 19th century up to 20% of Britain's population lived in London, and by 1850 50% of the British population populated London.¹ This sudden increase in population overwhelmed the city of London and many individuals and families were forced to spend their nights in crowded rooms, sometimes with one or more families sharing a singular room.² The majority of the people who moved to London came due to the industrial revolution which suddenly created many jobs in miscellaneous factories.³ The working class had a crowded life which often caused sickness, most likely due to a shared toilet and water pump.⁴ Some of the houses used by the lower class were called "back to Backs" due to them only featuring a window at the front of the house as well as sharing a long gutter-like sewer that ran down the middle of the street.⁵ All this greatly increased child mortality as very few children made it to adulthood.⁶ In contrast to the above-mentioned, the middle- and upper class citizens of London lived very

¹ The National Archives, Victorian homes

² The National Archives, Victorian homes

³ The National Archives, Victorian homes

⁴ The National Archives, Victorian homes

⁵ The National Archives, Victorian homes

⁶ The National Archives, Victorian homes

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different lives.⁷ Their houses were well-built and often featured things such as flushing toilets, and gaslight,⁸ they were also often well-heated and clean.⁹ In 1875 a decision to remove the slums of London and build new houses in its stead was made, the destruction of the slums as well as the building process for the new houses did not happen at a swift pace and many who had before lived in the slums simply moved to another slum, worsening the population density there, as very few could simply afford to buy a new house.¹⁰ As mentioned it was not uncommon for streets, especially in the less affluent parts of London, to have open sewers that not only made its general vicinity odious but also supplied a rich breeding ground for diseases such as cholera, diphtheria¹¹ and typhoid fever.¹² In Addition to this, the closeness in which many of the lower class lived also provided the various bacteria and viruses with plenty of opportunity to spread. The working class life was a hard one mainly consisting of long shifts, 12 to 14 hours long repeated over 7 days, low wages, with men being paid the highest, a whole 15 shillings or 75 pence and children 3 shillings or 15 pence, a work environment filled with dangerous machines, that often clobbered and maimed arms, fingers or legs, as well as harsh punishments, fines or buckets of ice water thrown at them.¹³ One social class that prospered during all this was the middle class, also known as the bourgeoisie.¹⁴ This class consisted of those who had secured themselves as merchants and shopkeepers¹⁵ and mainly flourished due to the general increase in production and demand for goods and services.¹⁶ The middle class gained more money and therefore had the resources to buy “novelties” from the country’s factories and most even began to employ servants.¹⁷ The lucky few who found themselves in the upper class did not have to perform any kind of manual labour as the upper class generally consisted of landowners.¹⁸

In summation, the living conditions during the Victorian era varied greatly based on social class. Those who were landowners and therefore considered the upper class had little to worry about as they did not need to perform any sort of manual labour. The middle class prospered greatly during this time period and while not as well off as the upper class, they were in a secure position, especially compared to the working lower class who often faced death due to rampant diseases and work-related accidents. The lower class often lived in small, poorly constructed, and crowded buildings in neighbourhoods in which disease spread easily due to the closeness and poor sanitary options.

⁷ The National Archives, Victorian homes

⁸ The National Archives, Victorian homes

⁹ The School Run, Live in the Victorian Era

¹⁰ The National Archives, Victorian homes

¹¹ The National Archives, Victorian homes

¹² English History, Victorian diseases

¹³ Twinkl, Living conditions in Victorian cities (2023)

¹⁴ English heritage, Victorians: daily life

¹⁵ British literature wiki, social life in Victorian England

¹⁶ English heritage, Victorians: daily life

¹⁷ English heritage, Victorians: daily life

¹⁸ British Literature wiki, social life in Victorian England

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Religion in Victorian Society.

Religion was quite important to the Victorians as many of the Victorians' virtues and much of their moral was governed by religious teachings.¹⁹ The Church of England, who before ruled the religious sector almost unilaterally, was being challenged, not only by different Christian denominations,²⁰ but by the continuous advances in science.²¹ This of course created quite a bit of turmoil within Victorian society. Religion held such a big role that those who could read would read the bible often and many went to church on Sundays.²² The Victorian era also saw a revival of church building.²³ All of this collaborated to religion being brought more into focus, both to participate in but also to scrutinise.²⁴ The nineteenth century all in all experienced a revival of religious activity and focus on religion that had not been seen since the days of the Puritans.²⁵ As previously stated this revival of religion brought with it the virtues that characterise much of the Victorian society that we know now and infused most if not all behaviour with a level of moralism, that can only be characterised by "Victorianism".²⁶ This revival of religion did not last as more and more public figures denounced their religious beliefs in public and as science, such as Charles Darwin's evolutionary theory, became more known.²⁷ The revival of religion was not only felt by the church but by the world of paintings as well, which sought to capture the very essence of Christianity and morality in art.²⁸ With the rise and decline of Christianity in Victorian society came the rise of spirituality and mysticism.²⁹ With spiritualism came an increasing interest in seances all in an effort to communicate with the deceased, or rather that the deceased was trying to communicate with the still living.³⁰ The spiritualism best associated with the Victorian era emerged in the late 1800s and attracted even queen Victoria's attention.³¹ Spiritualism might have had as good a hold as it did due to two factors, the first being the women's rights movement at the time. This women's rights movement started in the mid-19th century and spiritualism might have been extra attractive in connection to this as women, in contrast to classic Christianity, were seen as being more spiritual than men.³² A second factor that contributed to the hold that spiritualism had, especially on the upper class, is its connection to death and the beyond. In an upper class society in which "unwrapping parties" were being held, to provide the guests not only the joy of seeing a real-life mummy being unwrapped in front of them but also experience the taste of ancient Egyptians remains,³³ in a society where widows were expected to wear mourning clothes for more than 2 years³⁴ and death photography was seen as a must in the

¹⁹ British literature wiki, religion

²⁰ British Literature wiki

²¹ English heritage, Victorians: Religion

²² Victorian era, Victorian era religion and religious beliefs

²³ English heritage, Victorians: Religion

²⁴ Altholz, 1976, L. 1-8

²⁵ Altholz, 1976, L. 2-4

²⁶ Altholz, 1976, L. 4-6

²⁷ English heritage, Victorians: religion

²⁸ Fraser, god and religion in Victorian literature

²⁹ English heritage, Victorians: religion

³⁰ Diniejko, 1988

³¹ Diniejko, 1988

³² Diniejko, 1988

³³ Harmes, 2022

³⁴ Funeral basics, 8 Intriguing Funeral Customs from the Victorian Era

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upper class³⁵ and a society where people kissed the corpse of their dead family member goodbye³⁶ as well as being surrounded by dangerous diseases might skew one's relationship with death and therefore make the idea of communing with the dead that much more intriguing.

To sum up, Christianity experienced a revival, but this revival came at a time where the science of evolution and the like was becoming more and more popular and therefore turmoil ensued between Christianity and science. After Christianity saw a decrease and an increase in spirituality arose and brought the attention of many, including the reigning queen, to it. Spiritualism's main pull came from the Victorians' odd relationship with death which caused a fascination with the idea of communing with the dead, something that spiritualism offered.

Sub conclusion

The living conditions in Victorian society were different depending on the social class. For the lower class, consisting of the unskilled working class and people of "questionable morals" to mention a few, life proved rather difficult. The housing was often poorly constructed, crowded, and required sharing a toilet and water pump between multiple houses on the street, which often led to contaminated water which led to sicknesses such as cholera, diphtheria, typhoid fever, etcetera. The working class worked hard underpaid jobs with harsh punishments and long shifts close to dangerous equipment. In contrast to this the upper class, consisting of landowners of various statuses, had fairly easy lives. They hardly had to perform any manual labour as the potential taxes that tenants paid on the land on top of various production supplied more than enough resources to hire workers and finance a more than comfortable life. Diseases were not unheard of in the upper class they did not ravage the nicer neighbourhoods in the same way as they did the slums. The middle class, which was made up of merchants and factory owners, prospered and many suddenly had enough money to hire servants and buy novelty trinkets. The presence of death, and the devastation felt especially by the lower class, caused a revival period for Christianity wherein there was an increase in religious activity. During this revival period, there was a struggle between different denominations of Christianity, in which the Church of England was challenged by other branches of Christianity. This revival period was, however, soon stopped as the focus shifted from religion over to Darwinism and general evolutionary science and interestingly enough spiritualism. Spiritualism had an especially strong hold on the Victorian upper class as the odd relationship that the Victorians built to death caused a huge interest in communing with the dead, which was allegedly achievable through the practice of spiritualism.

³⁵Funeral basics, year (N/A)

³⁶Woodyard, 2018

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Flower Girls and Reanimated Corpses

How Usable is "Of the Life of a Flower Girl"

To gain a better understanding of the living conditions during the Victorian era and the view that the upper- and middle class held of the lower class, during that same time period, it is relevant to look at the article "of the Life of a Flower Girl", but one can not take this article at face value as articles can be infested with biases and other discrepancies. Due to this, it makes sense to conduct a proper source-critical analysis of the article, where one looks at the different biases and the genuine usability of the source, in addition to the view into living conditions and the general society of the time.

In 1851 the journalist Henry Mayhew published an article titled "Of the Life of a Flower Girl" which was later compiled into a collection of his articles concerning the life of London's "street-folk". This collection was titled "London Labour and the London Poor". When conducting a historical source critical analysis of the article "Of the Life of a Flower girl" it becomes obvious that Mayhew has complicated feelings about the "street-folk".³⁷ The article is a contemporary source as well as a primary source, furthermore, it is also a first-hand account of meeting this flower girl, this is implied in the lines: "*One of this class, whom I saw*".³⁸ Since it is a contemporary source it makes the chances of it ringing more true to the conditions of the time than a text written later, the same logic applies to the source's status as a primary source, as it again has a smaller chance of being tampered with due to constant interpretation. One thing that should be noticed is the fact that the source is a first-hand account, this means that while the source is as close as it can get to the origin of the story, chances are that the events described are coloured by the author's biases. Since the nature of the source is an article it is a public and personal source, meaning it was published and available to the public, but it was not constructed by an institution. This gives the source a more intimate feeling as the language is vastly different from the more formal legal language than that of a text constructed by an institution as well as being read by more people as it is published to the public. The source is as stated earlier an article that was published in a well-known newspaper called "The Morning Chronicles". The article is written in English, which is the native language of the author, London-born Henry Mayhew. Henry Mayhew was a well-known journalist who wrote for the sun, and he was specifically known for the weekly periodical that described the lives of London's lower class people through first-hand accounts and interviews. The article was written to be read by the readers of "The Morning Chronicles" which mainly consisted of middle and upper class people, due to the price of the newspaper itself and the illiteracy that still, especially, riddled the lower class. The article "Of the Life of a Flower Girl" was published in 1851 which was in the middle of the Victorian period. A period that was rich in social inequality and a love for traditional family values. It was also a time that experienced a revival of religion and the fear of god. This has affected the text as there is a clear amount of judgement against women of "immoral character"³⁹ as well as disdain towards parents who act badly towards their wards.⁴⁰ The article was written while Henry Mayhew lived in London. The

³⁷ Mayhew, 1861, p. 32, l. 1-4

³⁸ Mayhew, 1861, p. 32, l. 4

³⁹ Mayhew, 1861, p. 32, l. 1-2

⁴⁰ Mayhew, 1861, p. 32, l. 2-4

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goal of the weekly periodical was to document the daily lives of London's "street-folk",⁴¹ in this specific scenario, flower girls. Although it is very likely that these articles also fed into the judging fascination that many in the middle, but especially, the upper class held towards the lower class.

The article is a retelling, by Mayhew, of a flower girl's life up until that point.⁴² The retelling is coloured by a peculiar fascination, from Mayhew's side, as he passes judgement onto the flower girl, her parents and others like them all the while sympathising with her:

"She was not nineteen, and had been sentenced about a twelvemonth before to three months' imprisonment with hard labour, 'for heaving her shoe,' as she said 'at the Lord Mayor, to get a comfortable lodging, for' she was tired of being about the streets'".⁴³

All in all, the article functions as a representative source for the conditions that many flower girls would have met in their day-to-day life. The source's credibility is only moderately acceptable since there is a great chance that the flower girl that Mayhew allegedly met is likely not a singular person but rather an amalgamation of multiple flower girls and their life stories. However, the credibility of the article is brought to a balance by Mayhew's credibility as a well-known writer and journalist for a well-known and well-esteemed newspaper, "The Morning chronicles". Despite the credibility, it would be wrong not to note Mayhew's biases which may have affected the article. Mayhew's biases are easily observed in the article itself, starting with the lines *"Some of these girls are, as I have stated, of an immoral character, and some of them are out by their parents to make a livelihood by prostitution"*.⁴⁴ These 4 lines demean not only flower girls and sex workers but also their parents. Nevertheless, this bias is balanced by the tone in Mayhew's retelling, as he adopts a sad melancholic aspect in his description of the happenstances of the flower girl. In the end, the article is a credible and telling source if one remains attentive to the biases embedded in the writing process and the effect they have had on the text. The happenings described to have happened in the flower girl's life are realistic and a good representation of the occurrences and living conditions that a lower class and, especially, a flower girl could experience, however, the occurrences described have a great chance of being a combination of more than one flower girl instead of the experiences on a singular flower girl. The oddness of Henry Mayhew's opinion of the lower class is quite visible here as we both see dismay at the idea of the flower girl's parents' treatment of her⁴⁵ as well as starting the article with those demeaning four, above-mentioned, sentences⁴⁶ in addition to being seemingly appalled by the lower class, all the while seeming sympathetic with the flower girl's cause. Something that heavily speaks to the credibility of the source is the fact that it is both a primary source and a first-hand account of the enclosed events, which puts the source as close as possible to the events.

⁴¹ Schroeder, 2019

⁴² Mayhew, 1861, p. 32-34, l. 4-17

⁴³ Mayhew, 1861, p. 32-33, l. 5-1

⁴⁴ Mayhew, 1861, p. 32, l. 1-4

⁴⁵ Mayhew, 1861, p. 32, l. 3-4

⁴⁶ Mayhew, 1861, p. 32, l. 1-4

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The source's portrayal of Victorian society and the time's living conditions is rather negative. Society seems cold and makes out a world children become a working force for their parents,

"She was sent out into the streets by her father and mother, at the age of nine, to sell flowers. Her father used to supply her with the money to buy the flowers, and she used to take the proceeds of the day's work home to her parents. She used to be out frequently till past midnight, and seldom or never got home before nine" ⁴⁷

And where an asylum is safe and gives one better living conditions than doing honest work by selling flowers.⁴⁸ The living conditions are not much better. The flower girl is younger than 19 years⁴⁹ old and yet she is out working at least until nine pm on good days and was often working till way past midnight as seen in the line *"She used to be out frequently till past midnight, and seldom or never got home before nine"*⁵⁰ The Victorian period is one characterised by rapid development and a quick change from a rural and agriculturally focused society to an urban and industrialised world.⁵¹ It is a time that saw great social inequality based on an individual's economy and family and it was a time that saw a rise of the middle class in addition to a new idealisation of family. All of these tumultuous changes are likely one of the reasons that there was even an interest in the lower class and their life. The value placed on family, mainly caused by the regent family relations, is a likely contributor to the disdain expressed in "Of the Life of a Flower Girl" in connection to parents' treatment of their children.⁵² The general unrest due to the industrialisation and urbanisation of society that happened, and caused harsher living conditions for the lower class as there was more competition over much the same number of resources. This again caused the lower class to "become more interesting" for the upper classes and the rise of the middle class brought new buyers to the newspapers. The usability of "Of the Life of a Flower Girl" as a historical source is another important question to ponder when conducting a source critical analysis. "Of the Life of s Flower Girl" can be used to show the life and living conditions that flower girls, and the lower class in general, have to contend with in their everyday life in addition to showing the view that the upper and middle class had of the lower class as well as what the picture of the lower class, the middle and upper class were being fed by the press. Moreover, "Of the Life of a Flower Girl" is also useful to see the weight family held in upper- and middle class society during this time, albeit it is not as obvious or in as much focus as the general living conditions and the view on said living conditions are. It is visible in the derision expressed by Mayhew when concerning the parents of flower girls.⁵³

⁴⁷ Mayhew, 1861, p. 33, l. 5-11

⁴⁸ Mayhew, 1861, p. 34, l. 9-17

⁴⁹ Mayhew, 1861, p. 32, l. 5-6

⁵⁰ Mayhew, 1861, p. 33, l. 10-11

⁵¹ Historical Association, Victorian Britain: a brief history

⁵² Mayhew, 1861, p. 32, l. 2-4

⁵³ Mayhew, 1861, p. 32-33, l. 2-7

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Relationships, Social Classes, and Religion in "Frankenstein"

In January 1818, the book "Frankenstein; or the Modern Prometheus" was published. The book was published anonymously, meaning the author's name was not listed.⁵⁴ The author's name is Mary Shelly and the choice to publish anonymously was one taken out of fear of losing custody of her children. The novel was written by an 18-year-old Mary Shelly and was completed in two years.⁵⁵ Shelly reportedly started the book when challenged by friend and renowned poet, Lord Byron, to a competition to see who could write the superior ghost story.⁵⁶ "Frankenstein; or the Modern Prometheus" is heavily affected by the time in which it was written and is especially affected by the struggle between social classes that ruled the era. This is seen in the way the social setting is presented throughout the story. Throughout the novel, we, the readers, are introduced to four different layers of society. At the start, the character Robert Walton is introduced as a seafarer and a private explorer.⁵⁷ This already signifies that he is of a fortunate background to not have to worry about the finances needed to fund such an expedition as the one he is on. It is also noteworthy that Walton's uncle is mentioned to have a private library that Robert could peruse in his younger days,⁵⁸ this again indicates a certain level of wealth. This in addition to the fact that Walton's father had a say in whether Robert should study and, perhaps more significantly, what Walton should study⁵⁹ all suggest the life of a lower-upper class or an upper-middle class family. The next layer of economic and social standing that we, the readers, are introduced to is that of the Frankenstein family. The Frankenstein family are a family of good standing and many means. This is most of all obvious by the social status the family has gained by multiple generations of family working in public positions as councillors and syndics.⁶⁰ Their status is further solidified by the implied number of servants working at the Frankenstein estate and the amount of money spent by them throughout the telling, Victor's college, transport, and housing when travelling and in Ingolstadt to mention a few of the larger expenses. All of this points to the Frankenstein's being a part of the Genevese upper class. In connection to the Frankensteins are Henry Clerval and his family. The Clervals are described to be merchants⁶¹ in a good enough financial state that they can afford to send their son to the same school as the upper class children.⁶² This signifies an upper/middle class family. In stark contrast to all the above-mentioned characters and their family is the Da Lacy family. The De Laceys are very clearly a lower class family. not only are they decidedly poor and lacking in some very crucial resources, such as food.⁶³ An interesting aspect of De Lacey's unfortunate state is the detail that the De Laceys originally held a middle to upper class status, but were exiled from Paris, their home country, due to breaking a man out of prison.⁶⁴ In his letters to his sister, Robert Walton also describes the working class sailors with whom he travels in a generally

⁵⁴ Lepore, 2018

⁵⁵ SparkNotes, "Mary shelly and Frankenstein background"

⁵⁶ SparkNotes, "Mary shelly and Frankenstein background"

⁵⁷ Shelly, 1818, P. 15, L. 3-16

⁵⁸ Shelly, 1818, P. 14, L. 30-32

⁵⁹ Shelly, 1818, P. 14, L. 32-37

⁶⁰ Shelly, 1818, P. 30, L. 2-6

⁶¹ Shelly, 1818, P. 35-36, L. 39-1

⁶² Shelly, 1818, P. 35-36, L. 37-1

⁶³ Shelly, 1818, P. 107, L. 6-14

⁶⁴ Shelly, 1818, P. 188-121, L. 5-39

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positive tone.⁶⁵ All these different social classes are represented in realistic ways, no one class is described as being the best class, simply being more or less fortunate all the while presenting the reader with a fairly believable idea of both the struggle of the lower class as well as the life of the upper class.

An interesting detail is a parallel between Victor and his creation and the social class struggle. If one chooses to look at the relationship between the story's antagonist and protagonist, there is a clear parallel between them and the class struggle taking place at the time. While Victor spends his time in comfortable, warm houses without the fear of starving, the monster lives in small hovels and wears clothes that barely keep him warm.⁶⁶ Victor's fear of and loss of control over the monster perfectly characterise the upper- and middle class's dependency on the working class to do what they were told to.

In short, Mary Shelly's novel "Frankenstein; or the Modern Prometheus" encapsulate the class struggle of the time through the presentation of the different social settings, that the characters in throughout the story navigate. The Frankensteins are in an upper class setting, the Clervals and the Waltons are in an upper-middle class setting and lastly, the De Laceys are in a lower class setting. In addition to this, the relationship between Victor and his creation perfectly captures the relationship between the upper class and the lower class during the class struggle that was happening at the time the novel was penned.

The relationship between Victor Frankenstein and his creation, the monster, is extremely interesting as there is a clear element of complexity and mirroring between the two characters. It is obvious that immediately after the successful creation of the monster Victor feels a great deal of abhorrence, fear and guilt due to the things that he, Victor, had done to create the monster⁶⁷ but up until the very success, Victor feels prideful over his accomplishment.⁶⁸ Victor is quick to transfer this complex mesh of emotions from himself and his actions to the creature he had created.⁶⁹ This in turn makes Victor fearful and hateful of the monster.⁷⁰ Victor also describes, to Walton, the relationship between himself and his creation to be one of fate.⁷¹ The monster's relationship with Victor is a complex one. On one hand, the creature connects much of his being and purpose to Victor's existence,⁷² on the other hand, he feels that Victor has done him a great misdeed by creating him.⁷³ This all makes the relationship formed between the antagonist and protagonist a complicated and complex one. There is also an element of mirroring between Victor and his creation. This means that the two characters are each other's foil characters. Both Victor and the daemon are isolated from society,⁷⁴ although in the creature's circumstance, this isolation is not of his own goodwill.⁷⁵ In much the same sense both characters feel a great amount of guilt when thinking about the murders that happen as an extension of Victor's and the monster's strained

⁶⁵ Shelly, 1818, P. 18-19, L. 12-18

⁶⁶ Shelly, 1818, P. 98, L. 31-37

⁶⁷ Shelly, 1818, P. 55, L. 32-35

⁶⁸ Shelly, 1818, P. 55, L. 10-19

⁶⁹ Shelly, 1818, P. 55, L. 24-26

⁷⁰ Shelly, 1818, P. 56, L. 17-22

⁷¹ Shelly, 1818, P. 29, L. 17-23

⁷² Shelly, 1818, P. 214-215, L. 13-15

⁷³ Shelly, 1818, P. 124-126, L. 36-5

⁷⁴ Shelly, 1818, P. 35, L. 34-35

⁷⁵ Shelly, 1818, P. 101-102, L. 33-3

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relationship.^{76 77} in addition the fanatical rage in which they regard each other is also similar. Victor's fanaticism leads him to chase the monster across the world and eventually his death⁷⁸ and the monster's obsession with Victor likewise lead him to his suicide.⁷⁹ Another interesting resemblance between the monster and his creator is the way they both find solace in nature.^{80 81} In the end, the relationship between thematises many things, but perhaps the most obvious is Love V. Hate, Nature V. Nurture, and parenthood. Love V. Hate is seen in the daemon's feelings regarding his creator,⁸² Nature V. Nurture is meant in the sense that Victor and the monster are similar and that the differences in upbringing may be the cause of the differences. While Victor grew up in a loving environment⁸³ and therefore never sought out the act of hurting others until the creature started hurting Victor and his family, the Creature grew up in a harsh environment where he was met with bullets and stones thrown his way⁸⁴ and therefore developed a coldness that Victor does not possess. This proves that even though the creature was made by a man who, at the time, had no intention of hurting anyone, that intent, that nature, simply does not transfer over without proper nurturing. The theme of parenthood both in the book, but especially in Frankenstein's relationship with his creation, is perhaps the most obvious one. While Victor's parents are presented as an idealised version of a married couple and parents⁸⁵ Victor's role as a "parent" to the monster is dreadful.⁸⁶

In summation, the relationship between Victor and the monster is a complex one, marked with bitterness, love, hope and hate. Victor and the daemon mirror each other in many ways, they are both isolated from society, and they are both brought to their end by their obsession and fanaticism. The relation between the two thematises love/hate, nature/nurture, and parenthood. The last one is especially obvious and is particularly obvious when contrasting with Victor's parents.

Throughout the story of Frankenstein, religion is mentioned or alluded to multiple times. It is seen in the character of the monster, in Victor's actions, in the books mentioned by the daemon, and in the way, it plays up against science. The monster compares himself to Adam.⁸⁷ Although he quickly rebuffs this comparison and instead likens himself to John Milton's Satan, saying that where Adam had been born perfect and had been given all sorts of opportunities, he, the monster, had been alone and wretched.⁸⁸ The inclusion of Satan from paradise lost tells us, the reader, a lot about what we are supposed to feel for the monster. In "Paradise Lost" we hear the story of Lucifer's rebellion from Satan himself's point of view, inspiring sympathy for the devil. By comparing himself to Satan, the monster, in a sense asks for the same sympathy. A very important factor in "Paradise Lost" and "Frankenstein" alike is inspiring sympathy for the "Evil" character while not dismissing the bad things they

⁷⁶ Shelly, 1818, P. 86, L. 4-22

⁷⁷ Shelly, 1818, P. 214, L. 1-8

⁷⁸ Shelly, 1818, P. 196-197, L. 34-33

⁷⁹ Shelly, 1818, P. 214-215, L. 1-18

⁸⁰ Shelly, 1818, P. 72-73, L. 27-12

⁸¹ Shelly, 1818, P. 141, L. 19-27

⁸² Shelly, 1818, P. 214-215, L. 13-15

⁸³ Shelly, 1818, P. 31-34, L. 19-23

⁸⁴ Shelly, 1818, P. 136, L. 6-20

⁸⁵ Shelly, 1818, P. 31-34, L. 19-23

⁸⁶ Shelly, 1818, P. 56, L. 13-24

⁸⁷ Shelly, 1818, P. 125, L. 12-13

⁸⁸ Shelly, 1818, P. 125, L. 14-20

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have done, presenting them, the "evil" characters", not as heroes or great villains, but as someone to pity. "Paradise Lost" also thematises a creator/creation relationship as seen in "Frankenstein". This again tells the reader a lot about how they are supposed to feel about the monster and his relationship with Victor. When comparing the daemon to Satan it is also pertinent to compare Victor to God as Victor and his monster are in clear juxtaposition to Milton's God and Satan. Victor's actions can be considered godlike, and his hubris is blameable for the tragedy that his life becomes after the creation of the daemon. While Victor may be able to create life, like God, his reaction to the monster's completion⁸⁹ shows how wholly unprepared he is to be a creator/father. One quality that both "Paradise Lost"'s God and Victor Frankenstein share is the lack of self-criticism. Neither God nor Victor is willing to see their fault in the whole conundrum, not willing to see the hurt they are causing their creations. A last but perhaps even more relevant use of religion in Shelly's "Frankenstein; or the Modern Prometheus" is the parallels drawn to the fight between religion and science that was happening at the time. This battle is represented in the text by science infringing on religion's "jurisdiction" by creating life, but religion's failure to keep Victor grounded as his hubris is the start of his downfall.

In brief religion in "Frankenstein" is used to compare and contrast characters. This is done, not only with the biblical version of certain characters but also with characters from John Milton's "Paradise Lost". "Frankenstein" also shows the fight between religion and science by letting science infringe on religion, by Victor creating life, and by showing religion's failure when Victor's hubris causes his death.

Sub conclusion

The article "Of the Life of a Flower Girl" is a first-hand account, Henry Mayhew was a well-regarded is most known for his journalistic work in connection to the lower class of London. The article was published in a time period showered in social inequality and family values. The article's purpose was to document the lives of the "street-folk" however it is tremendously plausible that the articles were also there to feed into a certain type of judgemental fascination that the upper/middle class had. The source is representative of the life that many lower class denizens lived. It should be noted that there are biases in the source as Mayhew's opinion of the lower class is a clear mix of fascination and judgement. The historical circumstances of the source are rapid changes in societal structure and a sudden idealisation of family. The source is useful to gain a look into the living conditions and life of the lower class and the picture of the lower class, the upper/middle class was fed by the press. The view on social classes and the importance of family is also described in Mary Shelly's "Frankenstein" as it gives a good view into the class struggle that persisted in the 1800s and thematises a parental relationship. Through the presentation of the different social classes, the struggles of each class are seen. Victor's relationship with his monster captures the struggle between the upper class and the lower class. The relationship between Victor and his monster is complex and the two thematise parenthood. Victor and his monster mirror each other greatly, both of them are isolated from general society, and both meet their demise due to obsession. Religion in Frankenstein is used to compare and contrast characters. Religion is often used with "Paradise Lost". The story shows the tussle between Science and religion, by showing religion's failings as well as science's infringement on religion.

⁸⁹ Shelly, 1818, P. 55, L. 24-26

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Macabre Fascinations, social inequality, and relevancy

Living Conditions and Societal structures' Effect on Victorian Literature and a Fascination with the Macabre

When looking at Mary Shelly's "Frankenstein; or the Modern Prometheus" and Henry Mayhew's "Of the Life of a Flower Girl" it is obvious that the tumultuous state of the societal structure and the shoddy living condition that at least 30,000⁹⁰ people lived in, has affected the literature. It is seen in the interest given to Mayhew's articles about the "street-folk" of London and it is seen in "Frankenstein" in Victor's hopes for being able to re-animate the dead, and effectively remove any worry of sickness and starvation.⁹¹ We also see an increase in horror stories as well as the creation of a new subgenre, titled penny dreadfuls. Penny dreadfuls were cheap and short horror stories or plays filled with blood, supernatural entities, and murder. The penny dreadful genre holds some of the most famous classic works of literature ranging from the original vampire novel, Sheridan Le Fanu's "Carmilla" to Oscar Wilde's "The Picture of Dorian Gray" and even stories without a supernatural element like the likes of "The String of Pearls" featuring a well-known barber, Sweeney Todd. The prevalence of these books can easily be attributed to the fascination that the upper class Victorians formed with death and with the increase in death rate⁹² due to a higher population density causing more sickness to spread and general shoddy living conditions. The increase in death rate⁹³ (alongside the causes for this increase) and the bigger focus on family are all likely contributors to the different macabre post-death rituals like death photography or kissing the dead goodbye. This in turn, as discussed, caused the more dark and macabre turn in literature. The struggle between the classes likely caused a lot of focus on the societal structure and living conditions, especially concerning work conditions and wages for factory workers as strikes and unionising happened more and more often. This focus of course affected different literature but especially affected the new papers that published many an article about the struggle and the living conditions and life in the lower class. This plays into a phenomenon that is still seen in the press today, where the more shocking and disturbing the news is, the more likely it is to be written about. Many of the living conditions that the lower class lived with did, as mentioned, before affected literature and the fascination with the macabre, but the living conditions of the upper class are not something to scoff at. the upper class had plenty of money, time and resources to enjoy things like absinth, mummy unwrapping parties and more, of course only increases the interest in the macabre, the upper class also has a high chance of participating in "poverty porn" or developing a saviour complex, wanting to help those "poor, dirty, uneducated peasants", both of which creates a focus and interest in the living conditions and societal structure and the difference between the living conditions for different social classes.

⁹⁰ Picard, 2009

⁹¹ Shelly, 1818, P. 38-39, L. 37-5

⁹² Davenport, 2020

⁹³ Davenport, 2020

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Is "Frankenstein" Still Relevant Today?

Enclosure A presents some excellent points as to why the themes in "Frankenstein" are still relevant today. The main themes that enclosure A mentions are the dangers of science going too far,⁹⁴ the ethics of science,⁹⁵ taking responsibility for the consequences of one's actions,⁹⁶ and the dangers of blinding ambition.⁹⁷ It is stated that the theme and moral of taking responsibility for the consequences of one's actions are even more important and relevant today than back in 1818 when Shelley first wrote "Frankenstein".⁹⁸ In the penny dreadful, "Frankenstein", this theme is most prevalent in the way Victor handles the monster immediately after the successful reanimation.⁹⁹ Victor abandons his responsibility for the monster that he has created the moment said monster is born, by running away, leaving his creation to fend for itself,¹⁰⁰ hoping it would die without his help. We see the consequence of Victor's running away, throughout the rest of the story. The danger of science is, according to Kiona N. Smith, the author of enclosure A, started asking some worrying questions about the line between life and death in the 1780s when the physicist Luigi Galvani started running electricity through dead limbs and saw the way said limbs contracted, this started a branch of science named Galvanism. A branch that concerned itself with electricity in physics, chemistry, and biology.¹⁰¹ Science going too far is more concerning than ever, with many people worrying over the consequences of genetic engineering, and artificial intelligence¹⁰² and fearing the potential that technology has. By extension, the fear of science going too far is the importance of ethics and ethical research in the world of science. In 2015 Doctor William L Gannon and Doctor Gary Harrison made a fake proposal to IRB, a committee responsible for deciding whether or not an experiment is ethical enough to conduct, on behalf of Victor Frankenstein, to prove the lack of ethics and how an ethics board could have stopped the events of "Frankenstein".¹⁰³ This is important to remember. If not adhering to certain ethical boundaries science and technology might be more advanced than now, but it risks losing the humanity of science. Now as, humanity stands on the precipice of multiple different scientific breakthroughs: genetic engineering, artificial intelligence, 3D printing organs and food, it is incredibly important that we remember our humanity and are ready to take on any potential consequences. A last but no less important theme/moral of "Frankenstein" that still applies today is the importance of not letting one's ambition blind one to the dangers of one's project.¹⁰⁴ In "Frankenstein; or the Modern Prometheus" this is seen in the title, where "Prometheus" is mentioned. Prometheus is, of course, being the titan who stole the fire from the Greek gods to give to humans and ended up punished. Fire is a major turning point in the history of technological advancement and while it can be a great tool, it can also cause great destruction, quite similar to ambition's ability to motivate but also its ability to lead to fanaticism. Blinding ambition is also seen in Victor's actions when bringing forth the monster. A theme in

⁹⁴ Smith, 2018, P. 2, L. 48-52

⁹⁵ Smith, 2018, P. 2, L. 40-45

⁹⁶ Smith, 2018, P. 1-2, L. 33-34

⁹⁷ Smith, 2018, P. 2, L. 55-60

⁹⁸ Smith, 2018, P. 1-2, L. 34-35

⁹⁹ Shelley, 1818, P. 55-56, L. 31-37

¹⁰⁰ Shelley, 1818, P. 55-56, L. 31-37

¹⁰¹ Smith, 2018, P. 1, L. 3-8

¹⁰² Smith, 2018, P. 2, L. 48-51

¹⁰³ Smith, 2018, P. 2, L. 36-48

¹⁰⁴ Smith, 2018, P. 2, L. 55-60

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"Frankenstein" that is not mentioned in Enclosure A is the theme of ostracization. In "Frankenstein" this is largely seen in the way the daemon is forcefully isolated by society¹⁰⁵ and dehumanised by Victor all due to the way he, the monster looks.¹⁰⁶ This is sadly still relevant today as there are still many who get turned away due to prejudice, based on their appearance being different but also due to their gender, sexuality, religion and/or culture. Now it can be argued that to make great developments in science, that in turn will help better human lives, ethics will have to be put aside. An example of this is testing makeup products on animals. Many consider animal testing unethical, but some consider it a necessary step to ensure the makeup is safe for human use. An argument can also be made that in some cases it is not one simply cannot take responsibility for the consequences of one's actions. An example of this would be if a doctor followed the correct procedures when treating a patient but the treatments does not work and the patient dies as a consequence of this. The doctor can not rightfully be blamed for this death as they did everything correctly. Despite this doctors are often on the receiving end of the critique and at times even lawsuits. In the end, many of these themes and morals are timeless because they teach an important lesson about ambition and diversity but also about ethics and the sacrifices that can and can not be made in the mission to make discoveries.

Sub conclusion

The societal structure and living conditions in the different societal layers have had a clear effect on the literature. Themes of societal struggle and criticism of the living conditions that the lower class is found in most books. The horror genre experienced an increase in interest with a whole new genre emerging. This new focus on horror is likely due to the amount of death and sickness in the daily life of the average Victorian citizen. This daily closeness with death, and the macabre in general, also created a fascination with death that is also seen in literature from the time. The struggle between social classes also caused more interest and focus on the difference in living conditions and the societal structure in general. The press was also affected by the turmoil between classes, writing more about it to feed the upper class's need for "poverty porn". Enclosure A argues that "Frankenstein" is still worth reading as the themes in it still apply to today's society. The themes, the enclosure touches on are Ethics, blinding ambition, responsibility, and science going too far. Blinding ambition in "Frankenstein" is seen in the title and in Victor's actions. This is still important today because ambition is still as useful a tool as it is destructive. Ethics, science going too far and responsibility as themes in "Frankenstein" are found in Victor's decision to bring the monster back from the dead and then leave. Today these are important due to the precursors of science we stand hanging on to humanity and being ready to take responsibility becomes more and more important. An unmentioned theme is "ostracization". It is seen by the way; the monster is treated by society and Victor. Unfortunately, many still judge based on prejudices. The main argument for the timelessness of "Frankenstein" is the themes and morals of "Frankenstein" are ones we still can learn from. It can be argued that some of these themes and morals, only apply to certain situations.

¹⁰⁵ Shelley, 1818, P. 101-102, L. 33-3

¹⁰⁶ Shelly, 1818, P. 57, L. 13-30

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Conclusion

The Victorian living conditions depended on social class. The lower class lived closely, disease spread fast, and worked dangerous, underpaid jobs. The upper class had easy lives with servants and warm houses. The middle class thrived and now had money to hire servants. Death's presence caused a short revival period for Christianity until science and spiritualism took over. Spirituality offered a chance to talk to the dead, something those fascinated with the macabre had an interest in. "Of the Life of a Flower Girl" is a first-hand account. It was published at a time of great social inequality, family values and rapid change in societal structure. The source was meant to inform of the lives of "street-folk" and to feed a fascination with a different life. The source's biases are a balanced mix of positive and negative elements. The source a useful insight into the lives of the lower class, the view the upper/middle class had of the lower class and the picture the upper/middle class were fed by the press. "Frankenstein" shows class struggle by showing social classes and their difficulties. Victor and his monster's relationship captures the struggle of classes and the theme of parenthood. The two mirror each other, both are isolated, and both die due to obsession. Shelly uses religion to compare and contrast characters. The monster is compared to Satan from paradise lost. The story shows the battle between science and religion by showing religion's failure and science's infringement on religion. Societal structure and living conditions had a clear effect on the literature. Themes of societal struggle and criticism of living conditions are seen in many books. The living conditions caused a spike in horror fiction and a fascination with the macabre. Societal struggle caused an increased interest in living conditions, this affected the writings of the press as well.

Enclosure A argues that themes like ethics in science, responsibility, and blinding ambition, which is found in "Frankenstein", are still relevant today, especially in the world of science. An unmentioned theme in enclosure A is "ostracization", which is still relevant with the prejudices many still hold. The main argument for the timelessness of "Frankenstein" is the themes and morals, relevancy even today.

In short, the societal structure present in Victorian England caused social inequality, this, along with the exploding population density in cities, resulted in horrible living conditions for the lower class. The bad living conditions led to a high mortality rate. This high mortality rate in connection with family being valued and the upper class having too much wealth led to peculiar customs concerning death and spirituality. This again caused a fascination with death and the macabre in general. This fascination and the living conditions, societal structure, etc. in turn, caused an interest in gory horror stories of death, sickness and the supernatural.

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